of the most valuable experiences of my career as it helped me understand the business from the inside out," she says.

As her responsibilities expanded across business development, strategy and executive leadership, her message to young women remained constant: do not assume operations are not for you. "Understanding operations is one of the strongest foundations for becoming a successful logistics leader," she says. "Don't feel that you have to behave like someone else to succeed. Know your business, be confident in your decisions, stay approachable and let your performance speak for you."

For Anamika Jain, CEO of AAJ Supply Chain Management, the understanding of logistics came from seeing what the business could become. When she first encountered logistics, she viewed it as a tactical business. That changed after visiting modern international warehouses around 2010. "I realised it's a science and there is tremendous potential for value addition," she says. Jain built her credibility by focusing on merit and operational excellence. "I always made sure my work preceded me, so I was judged on the merit of what we can do or have done."

Jain notes that modern logistics rewards foresight, structure and proactive management over crisis response. "The best teams are the ones which do not have to fire fight," Jain says.

BASIC BARRIERS

The women who have made it in logistics also reveal why many others never enter—or leave before reaching leadership. "When we started building modern warehouses, I insisted that women would be on the floor, and that there would be proper, separate toilets for them," says Jani.

Women were trained as machine operators too. "Women are here to stay. They're not going to be consigned to a pretty voice in customer service," she added.



"And if the door still does not open? Sometimes the answer is not to knock harder on the same door, it is to build another door"

KANIKA TEKRIWAL
FOUNDER & CEO, JETSETGO



"Our industry is full of 'nepo kids', but only the toughest and the ones who work hard survive"

CHAITALY MEHTA
DIRECTOR, EKF GLOBAL LOGISTICS PVT LTD

Kothari encountered a similar problem when she entered Reema Transport. The absence of separate washrooms for women may have seemed like a small operational detail, but to her it was symbolic of the environment she was entering.

Mehta responded to the practical pressures facing women in her own workplace by building flexibility into the organisation, including nursing spaces and period leave. "I'd rather have someone take a day off than have them mess up on a shipment," she says.

"The first thing we need to recognise is that the jobs are there. What's missing are the conditions women need to take them up and stay," says Goyal of Udaiti Foundation.

The barriers are interconnected. "Mobility and safety come first: can she get to work and back safely? Assets are next: does she own a vehicle or a smartphone? Care is third: who looks after her children during a 10-hour shift?" Goyal notes. "Fixing just one rarely changes much."

The numbers highlight the mobility barrier. A 2025 study by Udaiti Foundation and Quess revealed that 57% of women in the blue- and grey-collar workforce report mobility challenges, while 61% rely on public transport.

Technology can reduce some of the physical demands of logistics and create last-mile opportunities, but it cannot solve infrastructure by itself. "An app can assign a delivery. It can't give a woman a vehicle, a safe route home at 10 pm, or childcare," says Goyal. Jani sees the business case as straightforward. "We have 50% of the country that is women. It is a direct ROI."

As logistics becomes more organised and technology-driven, the question is no longer whether women can do the work. The harder question is whether the industry can build the infrastructure, networks, workplaces and leadership pipelines that allow many more women to enter, stay, and progress. BT